did come from far, far behind. After inventing the game in an ancient time of leisure, and passing it on to the world via Persia, India had dropped off the chess map. In the 25 editions of the tourney thus far, the Soviet bloc had been hegemons—winning 14 times, the USSR itself eight times. Three of those whiz kids—Boris Spassky, Anatoly Karpov and Garry Kasparov—had already gone on to become senior World No. 1. There, in the history of the International Chess Federation (FIDE) championship since 1948, they had lengthened the list of Soviet champions to a dozen, who had by then kept the title for 35 years. A little Indian was breaking that Russian checkmate, en route to his own high-altitude plateau—a span from 2000-12 where he became world champion five times.

It wasn't in the script. Back when Anand was vying for the junior title, all of Asia was missing from the modern pecking order. Funny to recall that today when two Asians—China's reigning world champ Ding Liren and Indian challenger Gukesh Dommaraju—have just finished a long, breathless grapple for the title, which the 18-year-old Indian won! How much the world of chess changed with Anand goes beyond his titles—to appreciate that, look at the things that don't change. Today, it's Gukesh who sees barbs rather than bouquets come his way from ex-world champions like Vladimir Kramnik and Magnus Carlsen—for quality, Kramnik even called it "the end of chess as we know it". The déjà vu, for Anand, would have been intense. In 1991, a Russian grandmaster had told him that, minus Russian tutoring, he could "at best be a coffee-house player". Part of Anand's story is how the repartee was given not by him as an individual alone, but a nation that today has a standing army of 85 grandmasters and the world's youngest champion ever. As a spectator sport, chess is a bit like watching the paint dry: too much for TikTok-long attention spans. But if the idea of conquering the world with the mind was still strangely seductive, and pulled in so many that India was being called the "best chess nation" even before Gukesh's title, credit a six-year-old boy in Eastmancolor. ■

PAWNS TAKE IT ALL

» Anand's solo flight to the top inspires a whole chess renaissance in India

» The active Top 10 from India's 85 grandmasters have an avg. Elo rating—a dynamic ranking of skill levels used by FIDE—of 2703, the world's second best

» In 2020, amidst the pandemic, Vishy set up the WestBridge Anand Chess Academy. He chooses five GMs to mentor. Among them is young Gukesh

» It's Anand who sets up Gukesh with coach Grzegorz Gajewsi



FROM THE ARCHIVES
Jan. 8, 2001

Cover Story
The Genius of Anand

Alexei Shirov had spent a good portion of the past hour holding his head like a man with a migraine.... The other man, moving as quickly as he plays, shook hands with the most restrained of smiles. The crowd began to surge towards the table in one great, grey wave. In another time, they would have been arrested for indulging in a sport banned by the Iranian revolution.

–Sharda Ugra

"Criticism just comes with the territory. You ignore it, and that's all"

— VISWANATHAN ANAND, *advising disciple Gukesh D. after ex-champs made light of the 18-year-old's feat of winning the World Chess Championship 2024*